

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

ALT this month:

Inside this crazy section this month we look at various ways in which fans celebrate their love of franchises, delve into the past decade of popular apps, get a regular dose of dgt, and round it all up with interviews with industry experts from Seagate, Oracle and Route Mobile...



Gene altered mosquitoes released

Researchers have released genetically engineered mosquitoes in a high security lab. These mosquitoes have been bred to spread infertility among wild mosquitoes, which is a population control measure. There are ethical questions of releasing such animals in the wild, as the consequences on the ecosystem are unknown.

<https://dgit.in/gamosq>

AI finds emotions in buddhist statues

Buddhist statues traditionally are not supposed to display any emotions, and not even genders. The sculptors were given explicit orders to make the statues as indifferent as possible as it was considered to be closer to perfection. However, humans are humans, and emotions are strong within us, and researchers are using AI to figure out which expression the sculptor intended to convey. There were some surprising results: for example, expressions of a single statue change from happy to sad based on what angle you look at it from. Some favoured angry expressions, while others leaned towards happy expressions. The researchers from Nara University believed



that humans should not judge the Buddhas, because of their religious significance, but it's ok if an AI does it. The purpose of the project is to "provide people with a means for reaffirming the beauty of Buddhism."

<https://dgit.in/aistat>

Global population may decline in the future

According to the United Nations, the human population is on track to reach 11 billion by the end of the century. A journalist and a political scientist, who have published a book called "Empty Planet", believe that the prediction of exponentially increasing population is fundamentally wrong. John Ibbitson and Darrell Bricker believe that in about three decades, the world will reach its peak human population. After

that, the population will start declining, and never stop. Just one factor – the spread of female education – is inversely tied to birth rates, and this is predicted to be enough to reduce the population in 2100 to between 8 and 9 billion. The models that the UN uses to forecast



population growth, does not take into account these factors, and is rather simplistically based on just birth, death and migration rates. In the focus group interviews conducted by the pair, people wanted to have fewer children, all around the world.

<https://dgit.in/popdecline>



Lizard breaks rule of biology

Animals that have evolved to give birth to live young, do not (usually) revert to laying eggs, a principle known as Dollo's law. However, a species of lizard living in the Andes lays live young in extreme cold conditions, but lays eggs when it moved to colonise the surrounding lowlands.

<https://dgit.in/dololiz>



Chinese tech Superstitions

Chinese technology companies are known to start businesses on lucky dates according to the Chinese zodiac, ask Buddhist monks to bless gaming servers, include auspicious numbers in URLs, construct offices base don Feng Shui, etc.

<https://dgit.in/chitek>



Striped body paint deters insects

The tribal population of Africa, Papua New Guinea and Australia have traditionally painted stripes on their faces and bodies. Research shows that such patterns on the skin deters insects such as horseflies, tse tse flies, and black flies. This is the reason why Zebras evolved stripes.

<https://dgit.in/flystripe>